

Eastern and Western philosophies



In India and China, the differences between philosophy and religion are less clear than in the West.

Although the tradition that began in ancient Greece still tends to dominate philosophical discussion in the Western world, philosophy is by no means restricted to that single tradition. Thinkers such as Laozi and Confucius in China also founded their own traditions of philosophy from different starting points, as, arguably, did Buddha in India. For them, and subsequent Eastern philosophers, questions of metaphysics were considered to be adequately explained by religion – hence the Eastern traditions are much

more focused on concepts of virtue and the way in which we should lead our lives. In China especially, this moral philosophy was adopted by the ruling dynasties and took on a political dimension. Eastern and Western philosophies developed very separately until the 19th century, when European philosophers, notably Schopenhauer, began to take an interest in Indian religious and philosophical thought (see [The Universal Will](#)). Elements of Eastern philosophy have subsequently been incorporated into some branches of Western philosophy.